

The Boston Globe

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SATURDAY, MAY 30, 2026

A not-so-special 4th for struggling towns

Some are forced to choose between fireworks and layoffs

By **Chloe Pisani, Emily Spatz, and Lauren Albano**
GLOBE CORRESPONDENTS

Mounting financial pressures and difficult budget decisions are forcing some Massachusetts communities to do away with their Fourth of July celebrations.

Officials in Framingham and the Worcester County town of Rutland announced Wednesday that annual Independence Day events planned

for June and July are canceled due to budget and staffing issues. Several municipalities, which are still celebrating July 4, are relying on private donations and partnerships with local organizations, instead of local tax dollars, to fund their events.

The celebrations are the latest casualty of the financial crisis confronting communities throughout the state. Municipalities are increasingly struggling to raise enough local revenue to fund public safety personnel and school budgets. Their growing struggle to pay for essential services places town events more frequently on the chopping

block.

“I’m not surprised that a bigger place like Framingham and a smaller place like Rutland are having to make these types of decisions because of the larger fiscal challenges that cities and towns are facing,” said Adam Chapdelaine, executive director of the Massachusetts Municipal Association, a nonprofit which supports municipal officials.

Virtually all cities and towns in the state are facing budgetary challenges, according to a report the MMA published in October. Municipal watchdogs have said communities are facing skyrocketing inflation and increasing costs of essen-

tial services like health insurance and utilities.

Many municipalities are also limited in how much revenue they can raise through property taxes — the primary source of local revenue. Under a state law known as Proposition 2½, municipalities generally cannot increase property tax levies by more than 2.5 percent each year.

A growing number of cities and towns have asked voters to override Prop 2½ in recent years, warning that a lack of revenue could lead to cuts in public safety personnel and school budgets. Overrides are frequently unpopular with many vot-

FIREWORKS, Page A10

Funding for green justice could be cut in half

Budget proposals raise fears governor is stepping back

By **Kate Selig**
GLOBE STAFF

Governor Maura Healey swept into office pledging that environmental justice would be at the center of her efforts to tackle climate change, a commitment she backed up by allocating nearly \$9 million to the issue, an unprecedented sum.

The money helped launch a state office that strengthened oversight of energy projects in vulnerable neighborhoods and issued grants for tree planting and fresh produce distribution. And it created pathways for people frustrated with the environmental injustices in their towns to voice them to the state.

But just three years later, the governor and the Legislature have advanced budgets that would slash that funding by half.

Advocates say the loss of funds could threaten the state’s mandate to ensure its most vulnerable residents are protected from environmental pollution and the harms of global warming. Amid the Trump administration’s dismantling of federal environmental justice programs, some advocates worry that the Healey administration is stepping back its commitment.

“We were hoping for a bit more backbone,” said John Walkey, director of climate justice and waterfront initiatives at GreenRoots, an environmental group based in Chelsea.

FUNDS, Page A7

JON CHESTO

POWER PLAY

Healey, VCs battle business groups over noncompetes

By **Jon Chesto**
GLOBE STAFF

Brian Halligan strode to the mic, no notes in hand, after the Legislature’s economic development committee had endured three hours in a sweltering hearing room. His agenda: an old fight, rekindled.

The HubSpot cofounder and venture capitalist rattled off the ways that California’s tech scene has outpaced Boston’s: PCs, search engines, mobile. What about AI? (We’re well behind.)

Halligan detailed how a group left OpenAI five years ago to launch a rival. Now, that San Francisco company, Anthropic, is worth nearly \$1 trillion. Imagine that happening in Boston? Unlike California, Halligan said, we have at least one big thing slowing us down: noncompete agreements.

Get rid of the “whole darn thing,” he implored on May 19, in his first such State House appearance. Or at least end the “loophole” that undermines the state’s 2018 law limiting noncompetes.

NONCOMPETE, Page A10



PHOTOS BY LANE TURNER/GLOBE STAFF

The sign will be moved 120 feet away from its spot to keep it from being blocked, the way it is now from certain vantage points.

ALL TEED UP AND READY TO GO

Famed Kenmore sign is coming down, piece by piece, for relocation

By **Catherine Carlock**
GLOBE STAFF

The T was first to go down.

No, not the transit system. The central letter in Boston’s famed Citgo sign, which began its six-month, \$8 million refurbishment and relocation on Friday.

The 125,000-pound structure will be taken apart piece by piece, first with the existing letters and logos, by crews from Suffolk Construction. After cleaning, repainting, and repairing the sign — which measures 60 feet by 60 feet, each letter 11 feet high — it will be reinstalled on a new steel superstructure 120 feet away from its current spot atop 660 Beacon St. in Kenmore Square.

Developer Related Beal redeveloped a string of former Boston University buildings in the heart of the square in 2023, and incorporated support structures into the property’s elevator shaft at 660 Beacon St. to create what would eventually be a safe foundation for a relocated Citgo sign.

That elevator shaft is about 30 feet higher and 120 feet to the east from the sign’s current location, where it is now

CITGO, Page A10



“T” was the first letter removed on Friday. And in case you were wondering, each one measures 11 feet tall.

Five from Mass. killed in Va. bus crash

By **Shannon Larson and Laura Crimaldi**
GLOBE STAFF

GREENFIELD — Five people from Massachusetts, including a family of four traveling to a wedding, died early Friday morning in Virginia when a passenger bus slammed into a line of cars on Interstate 95.

The fiery crash, which happened roughly 40 miles south of Washington, D.C., at about 2:35 a.m. Friday, injured dozens of people and killed five: the Doncev family, of Greenfield in Western Massachusetts, and an as-yet-unidentified 25-year-old woman from Worcester who was traveling in a different car.

Virginia state police said the bus failed to slow down as it approached a work zone near Quantico, Va., and crashed into six cars before coming to a halt on the side of the road. There were 44 people hospitalized in the accident, and all five who died were in vehicles hit by the bus.

They included 45-year-old Dmitri Don-

CRASH, Page A7



VIRGINIA STATE POLICE VIA ASSOCIATED PRESS

The bus crashed into a line of cars slowing for a work zone in the early morning.



Slicker shock

Saturday: Wet, unpleasant.
High 50-55. Low 46-51.

Sunday: Some sun, warmer.
High 66-71. Low 51-56.

High tide: 11:43 a.m.,
11:42 p.m.

Sunrise: 5:11 Sunset: 8:13

Weather and Comics, D4-5.

VOL. 309, NO. 150

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Suggested retail price
\$4.00



A judge ordered that the John F. Kennedy Center for the Performing Arts remove President Trump’s name from the building’s facade and all branding, finding the board’s decision to add it was unlawful. **A6.**

A federal judge barred the government from taking steps to launch President Trump’s \$1.8 billion fund, for now prohibiting its establishment. **A2.**

Attorney General Andrea Joy Campbell sued UnitedHealthcare, alleging it intentionally made low-income older adults appear sicker than they were to boost its bottom line. **D1.**

The Trump administration’s lawsuit challenging Boston’s “sanctuary city” policies was dismissed. **B1.**

Eyes itching more than ever this spring? Blame the unusually cool start to May, which built up the release of pollen. **B1.**